Not until a few centuries ago did the idea of the Moon as a *place*, a quarter-million miles away, gain wide currency. And in that brief flicker of time, we've gone from the earliest steps in understanding the Moon's nature to walking and joy-riding on its surface. We calculated how objects move in space; liquefied oxygen from the air; invented big rockets, telemetry, reliable electronics, inertial guidance, and much else. Then we sailed out into the sky.

I was lucky enough to be involved in the *Apollo* program, but I don't blame people who think the whole thing was faked in a Hollywood movie studio. In the late Roman Empire, pagan philosophers had attacked Christian doctrine on the ascension to Heaven of the body of Christ and on the promised bodily resurrection of the dead—because the force of gravity pulls down all "earthly bodies." St. Augustine rejoined: "If human skill can by some contrivance fabricate vessels that float, out of metals which sink … how much more credible is it that God, by some hidden mode of operation, should even more certainly effect that these earthly masses be emancipated" from the chains that bind them to Earth? That *humans* should one day discover such a "mode of operation" was beyond imagining. Fifteen hundred years later, we emancipated ourselves.

The achievement elicited an amalgam of awe and concern. Some remembered the story of the Tower of Babel. Some, orthodox Moslems among them, felt setting foot on the Moon's surface to be impudence and sacrilege. Many greeted it as a turning point in history.

The Moon is no longer unattainable. A dozen humans, all Americans, have made those odd bounding motions they called "moonwalks" on the crunchy, cratered, ancient gray lava—beginning on that July day in 1969. But since 1972, no one from any nation has ventured back. Indeed, none of us has gone *anywhere* since the glory days of *Apollo* except into low Earth orbit—like a toddler who takes a few tentative steps outward and then, breathless, retreats to the safety of his mother's skirts.

Once upon a time, we soared into the Solar System. For a few years. Then we hurried back. Why? What happened? What was